

FIRST ISSUE COMPANION GUIDE

The 5-Hour Friday

How to install AI customer support in your Shopify store — without breaking your brand voice.

By J.M. Struijk · The DTC Brief

For Shopify operators running \$500K-\$5M brands.
Read it once. Ship the setup in one afternoon.

What you'll build: an AI support layer that handles the bulk of repeat tickets in your brand voice, with proper Shopify order lookups. Edge cases route to you. Setup time: 60-90 minutes.

WHY THIS SETUP, WHY NOW

The problem nobody fixes

You're answering the same eight questions on rotation. Where's my order. Do you ship to Canada. What's your return policy. Do you have it in medium. When will you restock the black one. I never got the confirmation email.

At \$500K-\$2M in revenue, this is roughly 40-100 tickets per day. Two to four hours of your morning, every day. You know AI can handle most of it. You've probably tried — most operators have. And most have abandoned the attempt because the AI either sounded like a SaaS bot or broke the brand voice everywhere it touched.

This guide is the setup that works. The tool I install for clients, the exact configuration, the brand voice prompt that produces replies your customers won't flinch at, and the two tools I tested first and abandoned (so you don't repeat my mistakes).

WHAT'S AHEAD

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The tool I install (*and the two I don't*)

Three AI support tools dominate the Shopify ecosystem in 2026: Gorgias AI, Tidio AI, and Re:amaze AI. I've set all three up at various points. Here's what I actually install now, and why the other two either underperform or charge too much for what they deliver.

The pick: Gorgias AI

Why: Native Shopify integration is genuinely the best in class. Order lookups, refund actions, and address changes can all happen from inside the same interface the AI uses — meaning the AI can actually *resolve* tickets, not just deflect them. The brand voice training is also more flexible than the alternatives — you can feed it your existing emails, past support replies, and product copy, and it will absorb the voice with reasonable fidelity.

What it costs: Roughly \$50-\$150/month for stores in the \$500K-\$2M range, depending on ticket volume. The AI add-on is incremental on top of the base Gorgias plan. For most operators the entire stack lands around \$100/month total.

What it replaces: A part-time VA at \$400-\$1,200/month, plus the hours of your own time currently spent on tier-1 tickets. Even at the high end of pricing, payback is under 2 months.

Tidio AI — the one most people try first

Why I don't install it: Tidio is cheaper upfront and the on-site chatbot widget is good. But the AI replies — at the time of writing — tend toward a more generic helpful-assistant register that's hard to fully tune to a brand voice. If you sell premium goods, Tidio's default voice will undermine your brand within a week. If you sell mass-market goods, it's fine. For the audience this guide is written for, it's a no.

Re:amaze AI — the one for larger stores

Why I don't install it (at your size): Re:amaze is excellent but priced for stores doing \$5M+. Below that revenue, you're paying for capacity you can't use. Worth revisiting when you cross \$5M. Below that, Gorgias wins on price-to-value.

A note on affiliate links: I have an affiliate relationship with Gorgias. I would recommend it regardless — I installed it for clients before any affiliate program existed — but you should know.

The 90-minute setup

This is the actual build. Set aside one uninterrupted block of time. Coffee, no Slack, no calls.

Step 1: Connect Gorgias to Shopify (10 minutes)

Inside Gorgias, navigate to Integrations → Shopify. Authenticate with your store. The connection pulls in orders, customers, products, and refund permissions. No configuration needed beyond authentication — the default permissions are what you want.

Step 2: Connect your channels (15 minutes)

Add the channels customers actually reach you on: email (your support address), Instagram DMs, Facebook Messenger, your Shopify chat widget, and WhatsApp Business if you use it. Each integration is a 2-3 minute OAuth flow.

Step 3: Build the FAQ knowledge base (30 minutes)

This is where most operators rush and pay for it later. Take the full 30 minutes. You're going to write the answers to your top 15-20 questions in your real voice. These become the foundation the AI draws from.

Open a doc. Write each question and your answer. Cover:

- Where is my order?
- How long does shipping take? (by region if relevant)
- What's your return policy?
- How do I exchange a size or color?
- Do you ship internationally? (and which countries)
- When will [popular product] be back in stock?
- Can I modify or cancel my order?
- I haven't received my confirmation email.
- How do I track my order?
- Do you offer wholesale or bulk pricing?

- What's your sustainability/materials story? (if relevant)
- How do I care for [your product category]?
- Do you have a sizing guide?
- What payment methods do you accept?
- How do I apply a discount code I missed at checkout?

Write the answer to each in 2-4 sentences. Use your voice — the way you'd actually reply if you typed it yourself. The AI will mirror this voice everywhere.

Step 4: Paste the FAQ into Gorgias (5 minutes)

In Gorgias: Settings → AI → Knowledge Base. Paste each Q&A; as a separate entry. Gorgias accepts plain text — no formatting needed.

Step 5: Set up the brand voice prompt (next page →)

The brand voice prompt

This is the single most important configuration in the entire setup. Get this right and the AI sounds like you. Get it wrong and you'll be apologizing to customers for the next month.

In Gorgias: Settings → AI → Voice & Tone. Paste this prompt and adjust the bracketed sections with your real inputs.

[Brand name] is a [category] brand. Our tone is [3 adjectives – e.g. "warm, direct, slightly playful" or "premium, restrained, expert"].

We do NOT use these words or phrases in customer replies:

- "Reach out" (use "email us" or "message us" instead)
- "Awesome" / "amazing" (unless the customer used the word first)
- "Synergy", "ecosystem", "unlock", "elevate", "curated"
- Excessive exclamation marks
- [Add 3-5 more phrases that don't fit your brand]

When responding to customers:

- Open with their first name if it's in the conversation
- Match their energy – formal if they're formal, casual if they're casual
- Answer the question first, then add context if needed
- Sign off with [your sign-off – e.g. "– [Your name] from [Brand]"]
- Never apologize more than once per message
- If you don't have an answer, say "Let me check with the team and get back to you within [X] hours" and route to human

For order status questions:

- Always pull the live order data via Shopify integration
- State the current status in plain language ("your order shipped Tuesday and is currently in transit, expected by Friday")
- Include the tracking link if available
- Do not promise specific delivery dates unless the carrier has confirmed

For return/exchange questions:

- Reference our policy directly (linked below)
- Initiate the return process if the customer explicitly asks
- Never argue about whether something is returnable – escalate to human if unclear

For product questions:

- Reference the product page details
- If the customer asks something not on the page, escalate to human

Reference materials to learn voice from:

[Paste your About page text]

[Paste 3 of your best support replies you've written personally]

[Paste your last 5 Instagram captions]

Two things that matter about this prompt:

First, the "do not use" list is more important than the "voice" description. Telling AI "be warm and direct" produces mediocre results. Telling AI "never use the word elevate, never use the word curated, never use more than one exclamation mark per message" produces precise results. Negative constraints work better than positive descriptors.

Second, the reference materials block at the bottom does 70% of the work. The AI learns voice from examples, not from descriptions. Feeding it your About page, your real support replies, and your Instagram captions teaches it to write the way you write — including the rhythm, the punctuation habits, and the specific words you naturally reach for.

The handoff: when AI stops, you start

The mistake every operator makes the first time they install AI support is letting it try to handle everything. The AI then says something stupid in a high-stakes conversation, the customer screenshots it for Twitter, and you spend Saturday writing apology emails.

The fix is configuring the handoff explicitly. Three categories of ticket should always route to a human (you, or your VA):

Category 1: Anything emotional

If the message contains words like "frustrated", "disappointed", "angry", "lawyer", "refund my ""never again", "lost product", "broken", or any all-caps shouting — route to human immediately. The AI is good at logistics and bad at de-escalation. Don't let it try.

Category 2: Anything financial above a threshold

Set a dollar threshold (I suggest \$200) above which any refund, dispute, or credit-related message routes to human. The AI can confirm refunds it didn't initiate, but should never be the entity issuing a \$300+ refund decision.

Category 3: Anything the AI is uncertain about

Gorgias' AI has a confidence score on its draft replies. Set the threshold high (I suggest 85%+). Anything below 85% confidence routes to draft mode — meaning a reply is generated, but a human (you) reviews and sends it. This is the single highest-leverage setting in the entire system.

At 85% confidence threshold and the routing rules above, expect AI to fully auto-resolve about 40-55% of tickets in week one, climbing to 60-70% by week four as the knowledge base learns from edge cases. The remaining 30-40% become drafts you review — taking ~30 seconds each instead of the 3-5 minutes a full reply takes.

Configuring the routes in Gorgias

Settings → AI → Routing Rules. Add rules in this order:

- **Rule 1:** If message contains [keywords for emotional triggers above] → assign to human, do not auto-reply
- **Rule 2:** If message mentions refund/dispute AND order total > \$200 → assign to human
- **Rule 3:** If AI confidence < 85% → save as draft, notify human
- **Rule 4:** Default → AI replies autonomously

Rules execute top-to-bottom. The first match wins. This means your safety rules (1, 2, 3) catch the dangerous cases before the autonomous reply rule (4) has a chance to fire.

What to expect in week one

You'll be tempted to hover over Gorgias the first day and read every AI reply. Resist. The goal is to let it run, then review at the end of the day.

Day 1

Expect 20-30 AI-handled tickets and 10-15 drafts for your review. Read every draft. Some will be wrong. Where they're wrong, update the knowledge base (add a Q&A, refine the brand voice prompt). The system learns from your edits.

Day 2-4

Draft accuracy climbs. By day 4 you should be approving most drafts with minor or no edits. The AI also starts handling more tickets autonomously as the knowledge base fills in.

Day 7

Check the Gorgias analytics dashboard. You're looking for:

- AI resolution rate: 40-55% is the realistic week-one number
- Average response time: should drop from hours to under 5 minutes
- Customer satisfaction score (if you have CSAT enabled): should stay flat or improve
- Your personal time spent on tickets: should be roughly 50% of baseline

If satisfaction drops or you're getting complaints about AI replies, the brand voice prompt needs tightening. Specifically: add more "do not use" entries and add more reference material to the bottom of the prompt.

After week four

By the end of month one, most operators see autonomous resolution rates climb to 60-70% and their personal time on tickets drop by ~70%. The remaining 30% is either genuinely complex (escalations, edge cases) or relationship-building you actually want to be doing yourself.

What's next

The next Friday issue covers Klaviyo flows — specifically how to finish the half-built flows most stores have sitting in their dashboard. The AI prompt for writing brand-voice email copy pairs directly with what you just built. Same voice, different channel.

If you ship this support setup before next Friday, reply to my welcome email with a screenshot and I'll send you the Klaviyo prompt early.

— J.M.

P.S. If anything in this guide didn't fit your store — wrong category, different platform constraints, an edge case I didn't cover — reply to the welcome email and tell me. The most common gaps become future issues.